

HINDU, NOT HINDI
An MNS poster with Raj Thackeray in Mumbai

forcing 6-10-year-olds to learn a third language, would reduce the mind space available for crucial subjects like maths. Ganpule also pointed out that, unlike the decision on English, there had been no consultations with experts on the Hindi issue.

GROWING ANTIPATHY

On April 22, school education minister Dadaji Bhuse said they were staying the order on Hindi. Although Fadnavis denied it, it is evident the impending local body polls led to the rethink. BJP sources say they did not want to be stuck with the 'anti-Marathi' tag, especially considering the belligerent support of non-Marathi groups for the party in Maharashtra. The Hindi issue also formed a conducive backdrop for politically estranged cousins Uddhav and Raj Thackeray to extend overtures for a possible rapprochement. Pratap Sarnaik, transport minister from the Shiv Sena (Eknath Shine faction), has stoked the fires further by publicly claiming Hindi has become Mumbai's "*bolibhasha* (lingua franca)".

Maharashtra and Tamil Nadu are hardly the only states militating against Hindi. There's a growing impatience with it in states such as Punjab, Telangana, Kerala and West Bengal. The battle has also sparked a larger debate on the need to protect India's linguistic diversity, with a fear that regional languages and dialects are being steamrolled by the Centre's push for Hindi. In Tamil Nadu, where the anti-Hindi agitation dates back to 1937 when the C. Rajagopalachari-led Madras Presidency government tried to make Hindi compulsory in schools, the debate has reopened old fissures and anxieties. Chief minister M.K. Stalin has called the NEP an instrument of "Hindi colonialism"; even as his son and deputy CM Udhayanidhi Stalin posted on X that this is not just a "language struggle, but also an ethnic struggle to protect Tamil culture". Stalin also crossed swords with Union education minister Dharmendra Pradhan after the latter allegedly threatened to withhold funds till Tamil Nadu complied.

Earlier this year, the Punjab government had made Punjabi a mandatory subject in the state's schools, saying students will have to study it as a primary subject to clear Class X. This came after it opposed the Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) draft norms for holding Class X board exams twice a year, claiming Punjabi has been left out of the subject list. The Telangana government too has now enforced Telugu as a mandatory language for students from Class I to X in all schools.

Last year, West Bengal implemented its State Education Policy (SEP), 2023 which, experts say, is essentially a covert replication of the NEP. The state government had earlier claimed it would not adopt the NEP, but the SEP introduces several NEP-like reforms, including the semester system in schools, interdisciplinary studies, four-year undergraduate courses and abolish-

"HINDI IS NOT BEING IMPOSED... ONLY MARATHI WILL BE COMPULSORY. BUT WHY OPPOSE HINDI, AND SING THE GLORIES OF ENGLISH?"

DEVENDRA FADNAVIS
CM, Maharashtra



"HINDI IS GETTING A POLITICAL PUSH. LANGUAGE IS TIED TO CULTURE, IDENTITY, AND THIS FORMAL EMPHASIS ON HINDI IS WHAT IRRITATES MANY IN THE SOUTH"

MANU S. PILLAI, *Historian*